
ACTOR REHEARSAL SCRIPT

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore

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A COMEDY IN THE MAKING

LUIGI PIRANDELLO • TRANS. EDWARD STORER (1922)

REWRITTEN AND DIRECTED BY KIARASH JAMSHIDI

VILLAGE PLAYERS, LAUSANNE

Working script for rehearsal. Dialogue, stage directions, and cues only.

All directorial readings, scorings, and production decisions in this edition are the work of Kiarash Jamshidi. Pirandello supplied the play; everything else around it is his.

DRAMATIS PERSONÆ

for an eight-performer staging across three stripped settings, with two stage objects in place of two of the children

The Six Characters

THE FATHER

THE MOTHER

THE STEP-DAUGHTER

THE SON

THE BOY

silent — coat and chair

THE CHILD

silent — wrapped bundle

MADAME PACE

embodied by Player 3

The Village Players — Lausanne

THE MANAGER

PLAYER 1

Leading Man · L'Ingénue · Door-keeper · Machinist · Third Actor

PLAYER 2

Leading Lady · Property Man · Fourth Actor · Second Lady Lead

PLAYER 3

Juvenile Lead · Prompter · Madame Pace · An Actor · Fifth Actor

TWO STAGE OBJECTS, NO PROJECTION

In this production the **Boy** is a wooden chair with a black coat folded over its back, a schoolboy's cap on the seat, and a small leather satchel at the chair leg. He is not played by a performer. Where the script asks the Step-Daughter to seize him or push him forward, she handles the chair and the coat. Where she pulls a revolver from his pocket, she pulls it from the coat hanging on the chair. The chair sits at the edge of the stage from the moment the Six walk on. In Act Three the Manager himself moves it behind the fountain basin; the revolver shot is heard, not seen.

The **Child** is a small wrapped bundle of white cloth, like a swaddling, with a black silk sash tied around it. She is carried, kissed, set down, and lifted again by the Step-Daughter and the Mother, from the moment the Step-Daughter walks on. The bundle is silent and motionless; it is moved only by other hands. The drowning at the fountain is hidden by the Step-Daughter bending over the bundle inside the basin; nothing is seen.

There is **no projection, no video, no screen** anywhere in the production. The Step-Daughter's Act Two opening monologue is delivered live, alone in the shower light, with the bundle in her arms and the chair-and-coat beside her. At the close of Act Three, as the Son narrates the drowning, the stage lights drop until only the fountain's interior glow and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain; the chair-and-coat is silhouetted behind the basin for ten seconds. Then full blackout. Then the gunshot, from where the chair-and-coat is.

Player 1, Player 2, and Player 3 are the working actors of the Village Players company. Their role labels in the script (Leading Man, Property Man, Prompter, Door-keeper, Machinist, Madame Pace, etc.) are functions, not separate characters. The cast list overleaf lists which Player carries which functions.

The Comedy is without acts or scenes. The performance is interrupted once, without the curtain being lowered, when the manager and the chief characters withdraw to arrange the scenario. A second interruption of the action takes place when, by mistake, the stage hands let the curtain down.



ACT THE FIRST

I



The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

The **ACTORS** and **ACTRESSES** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [*Il giuoco delle parti.*] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **PROMPTER** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.

The **PLAYERS**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.

Finally, the **MANAGER** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **SECRETARY** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **PROMPTER** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."

THE MANAGER [*throwing the morning's letter onto the table*]. I can't see a thing in here. [*To PROPERTY MAN.*] A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

PLAYER 2 (*as Property Man*) [*she has been at work for an hour; the Property Man's bearing — shoulders forward, weight on the front foot*]. Yes, sir. At once. [*A light comes down on to the stage.*]

THE MANAGER [*clapping his hands*]. Come along! Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and try, this time, to play it as if you wanted the public to come back for the third. [*Sits down.*] [*The ACTORS and ACTRESSES go from the front of the stage to the wings, all except the three who are to begin the rehearsal.*]

PLAYER 3 (*as Prompter*) [*reading the "book"*]. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

THE MANAGER [*to PROPERTY MAN*]. Fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 (*as Property Man*) [*noting it down*]. Red set. All right!

PLAYER 3 (*as Prompter*) [*continuing to read from the "book"*]. "Table already laid and writing desk with books and papers. Book-shelves. Exit rear to Leo's bedroom. Exit left to kitchen. Principal exit to right."

THE MANAGER [*energetically*]. Well, you understand: The principal exit over there; here, the kitchen. [*Turning to actor who is to play the part of SOCRATES.*] You make your entrances and exits here. [*To PROPERTY MAN.*] The baize doors at the rear, and curtains.

PLAYER 2 (as Property Man) [noting it down]. Right!

PLAYER 3 (as Prompter) [reading as before]. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, dressed in cook's cap and apron is busy beating an egg in a cup. Philip, also dressed as a cook, is beating another egg. Guido Venanzi is seated and listening."

PLAYER 1 (as Leading Man) [to **MANAGER**]. Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

THE MANAGER [annoyed]. I imagine so. It says so there anyway. [Pointing to the "book."]

PLAYER 1 (as Leading Man) [a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]. But it's ridiculous. I have a *reputation* in this canton. Or I had one, before this play.

THE MANAGER [jumping up in a rage]. Ridiculous? Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies — Paris seems to be keeping them all for itself — and we are reduced to putting on Pirandello, whom nobody understands, including (I am beginning to suspect) Pirandello himself, who plays the fool with all of us and pockets the royalties from the comfort of the grave? [The **ACTORS** grin. The **MANAGER** goes to **LEADING MAN** and shouts.] Yes sir, you put on the cook's cap and beat eggs. Do you suppose that with all this egg-beating business you are on an ordinary stage? Get that out of your head. You represent the shell of the eggs you are beating! [Laughter and comments among the **ACTORS**.] Silence! and listen to my explanations, please! [To **LEADING MAN**.] "The empty form of reason without the fullness of instinct, which is blind." — You stand for reason, your wife is instinct. It's a mixing up of the parts, according to which you who act your own part become the puppet of yourself. Do you understand?

PLAYER 1 (as Leading Man) [the threat empty; both of them know it]. I'd sooner resign. And I might.

THE MANAGER. Wouldn't we all, sir. But let's get on with it. It's sure to be a glorious failure anyway — and a glorious failure is the closest thing this house has to a guarantee. [Confidentially.] But I say, please face three-quarters. Otherwise — what with the abstruseness of the dialogue, the public that won't be able to hear a word of it, and the critics who will hear far too much — the whole thing will go to hell. And I'll be blamed for all of it. Come on. Come on.

PLAYER 3 (as Prompter). Pardon sir, may I get into my box? There's a bit of a draught — they have not yet fixed the door, you understand — and at my age, sir, that is how it begins.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, of course!

*The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The **DOOR-KEEPER** enters from the stage door, carrying a wooden chair with a folded black coat over the back, a schoolboy's cap on the seat, and a small leather satchel by the leg. He sets the chair at the edge of the stage, places the satchel on the floor beside it, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live **CHARACTERS** — **FATHER**, **MOTHER**, **STEP-DAUGHTER**, **SON** — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The **STEP-DAUGHTER** is already carrying a small wrapped bundle of white cloth, a black silk sash tied around it at the waist — that bundle is the **CHILD**, and remains so for the whole of the play.*

*A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality. The chair-and-coat at the edge of the stage is the silent fourteen-year-old **BOY**: from this moment on, the family treats it as him, speaks to it as him, and the audience reads it as him within seconds. No one is ever seen to play him.*

This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

*He who is known as **THE FATHER** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.*

***THE MOTHER** seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.*

***THE STEP-DAUGHTER** is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched chair-and-coat at the edge of the stage — the **BOY** in this production: a wooden chair, a black coat folded over its back, a cap on the seat, a satchel at its foot; on the other hand, she displays a lively tenderness for the small wrapped bundle of white cloth in her arms — **THE CHILD**, with a black silk sash tied around the bundle at the waist.*

***THE SON** (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **THE FATHER**, supercilious and indifferent to **THE MOTHER**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*

PLAYER 1 (as Door-keeper) [*cap in hand — the Leading Man's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

THE MANAGER [*rudely*]. Eh? What is it?

PLAYER 1 (as Door-keeper) [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

THE MANAGER [*without looking up*]. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! [*Turning to the CHARACTERS.*] Who are you, please? What do you want?

THE FATHER [*coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed*]. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

THE MANAGER *[half angry, half amazed]*. An author? What author?

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]*. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

PLAYER 3 *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh — do you hear that?

THE FATHER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To MANAGER.]* unless you would be willing...

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer, voice softening on each clause]*. Oh sir, you know well that life is full of infinite absurdities, which, strangely enough, do not even need to appear plausible, since they are true.

THE MANAGER. What the devil is he talking about?

THE FATHER. I say that reversing the ordinary process may well seem like madness: that is, to create credible situations, so that they appear true. But let me point out that if this be madness, it is the sole *raison d'être* of your profession, gentlemen. *[The ACTORS look hurt and perplexed.]*

THE MANAGER *[getting up and looking at him]*. So our profession seems to you one worthy of madmen then?

THE FATHER. Well, to make seem true that which isn't true... without any need... for a joke as it were... Isn't that your mission, gentlemen: to give life to fantastic characters on the stage?

THE MANAGER *[interpreting the rising anger of the COMPANY]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The ACTORS, satisfied, applaud their MANAGER.]*

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The ACTORS look at one another in amazement.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

THE MANAGER. But what do you mean? Before, you said...

THE FATHER. No, excuse me, I meant it for you, sir, who were crying out that you had no time to lose with madmen, while no one better than yourself knows that nature uses the instrument of human fantasy to pursue her high creative purpose.

THE MANAGER. Very well, — but where does all this take us?

THE FATHER. Nowhere! It is merely to show you that one is born to life in many forms, in many shapes, as tree, or as stone, as water, as butterfly, or as woman. So one may also be born a character in a play.

PLAYER 3 *[softly, to Player 2]*. Sorry — is this still the rehearsal?

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! *[MANAGER and ACTORS burst out laughing.]*

THE FATHER *[hurt]*. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

THE MANAGER *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, chuck it! Get away please! Clear out of here! *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

THE FATHER *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

THE MANAGER *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

THE FATHER *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the PROMPTER's box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[advances towards MANAGER, eyes level, not smiling]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

THE FATHER. Yes, that is the word! *[To Manager.]* The author who created us alive no longer wished, or was no longer able, to put us into a work of art. That was a real crime, sir. He who is born a character can laugh even at death. The writer dies; the creation does not — and it needs no extraordinary gift to live forever. Who was Sancho Panza? Who was Madame Bovary? They live eternally, because they found a fantasy that could nourish them. We had no such fortune.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, to no one in particular]*. He has been rehearsing this somewhere. You can hear the rehearsal in it.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

THE FATHER. We want to live.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

PLAYER 3. Just listen to him. Honestly — just listen.

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*) [*chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1*]. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

PLAYER 3 (*as Juvenile Lead*) [*pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER*]. I've no objection, as far as that one is concerned!

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. [*To the MANAGER.*] But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon concert it among ourselves.

THE MANAGER [*annoyed*]. But what do you want to concert? We don't go in for concerts here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

THE FATHER. It is in us! [*The ACTORS laugh.*] The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at him*]. His passion. Always the word *passion*. He uses it the way other men use cologne.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*crossing behind the Father, voice flat*]. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*. [*Places a deliberate hand on the FATHER'S shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.*]

THE FATHER [*angrily*]. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn.* [*Sings and then dances Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou.*]

*Les chinois sont un peuple malin,
De Shanghai à Pékin,
Ils ont mis des écriteaux partout:
Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou.*

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Bravo! Well done! Tip-top!

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the FATHER in consternation.]* Is she mad?

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when God takes this little darling from her mother, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest things — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

THE MOTHER *[to the MANAGER; one arm tightens around the bundle, the other goes toward the chair-and-coat as if to keep both of them upright]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the ACTORS]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the ACTORS brings a chair, the OTHERS proffer assistance. The MOTHER tries to prevent the FATHER from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife? *[To the FATHER.]*

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The ACTORS find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

THE FATHER. He isn't here, you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here — look at her a moment and you will understand — because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us. Perhaps a little gratitude. Not for me. For the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies, in fact, all in these four children she has had by two men.

THE MOTHER. *I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I wanted them? [To the COMPANY.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the bundle without her noticing].* Not true, isn't it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, it isn't true, it just isn't true.

THE MOTHER. And what can you know about it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To MANAGER.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the SON.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he *[Indicates the FATHER.]* made her do so.

THE MOTHER *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor].* He forced me to it, and I call God to witness it. *[To the MANAGER, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the FATHER.]* if it isn't true. *Let him speak.* You *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the chair-and-coat, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man) [to the COMPANY].* What a spectacle. What an absolute treat. I shall write to my agent — if I still have one.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* We are the audience this time.

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. For once, in a way.

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen]*. Let's hear them out. Listen!

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. *[To the MANAGER.]* He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

THE SON *[without looking up]*. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

THE FATHER. Phrases! Isn't everyone consoled when faced with a trouble or fact he doesn't understand, by a word, some simple word, which tells us nothing and yet calms us?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even in the case of remorse. In fact, especially then.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — for half an hour with a girl two months an orphan. *[Sensation of horror among the ACTORS.]*

THE SON *[to the STEP-DAUGHTER]*. This is vile.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who lure poor girls of good family into their ateliers, on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The girls are sometimes eighteen. Sometimes — they are not yet.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[Laughs ironically.]*

THE MOTHER *[a single word, not raised — addressed to the bundle, not the room]*. Shame, my daughter, shame.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, should turn your backs now — I am almost nude in this scene. I do not blush, however. *He* does. *[Indicating FATHER.]*

THE MANAGER *[the audience's confusion, on stage]*. I don't understand this at all.

THE FATHER *[he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read]*. Naturally enough. I would ask you, sir, to exercise your authority a little here, and let me speak before you believe all she is trying to blame me with. Let me explain.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

THE FATHER. But don't you see that the whole trouble lies here. In words. *Words.* Each one of us has inside him a whole world of things — his own world. Some of those things are unspeakable. So we speak around them. And how can we ever understand each other, if I mean one thing by my words and you hear another? We think we understand. We never really do.

THE MOTHER. But you drove me away.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

THE MOTHER *[looking at the floor between them].* You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir *[To MANAGER.]* — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

THE FATHER. But, good Heavens — it was just for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide in sign of desperation, seeing how hopeless it is to make himself understood.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has plenty of feeling. Oh yes, a good heart for the children. But — when I speak — nothing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the LEADING LADY who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the LEADING MAN flirting with the STEP-DAUGHTER, comes forward and says to the MANAGER.]*

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead) [the most earnest of the three, genuinely curious].* This is something quite new. I have not seen anything quite like this before.

PLAYER 1 *(as L'Ingénue) [the falsetto is half a beat too low; the Leading Man's voice is showing].* Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at LEADING MAN.]*

THE MANAGER *[to FATHER].* You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]* They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage — to exasperate me beyond measure.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

THE FATHER [*suddenly turning to the MOTHER*]. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*pointing at him, no smile*]. As one can see.

THE FATHER [*quickly*]. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's atelier. A very regular customer.

PLAYER 1 [*shifting in his seat, looking elsewhere*]. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

THE FATHER [*a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself*]. Fool! That is the proof that I am a man. This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a *live* man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman [*Indicating the MOTHER.*] any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*flat, into the room*]. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

THE FATHER. Yes, I admit it. It was also a liberation for me. But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir; and I did it more for her sake than mine — I swear it. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you until that other man carried you off to another town? Out of pure interest in you, that had no base motive in it, I watched with the tenderest concern the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was a kiddie, so so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and knickers longer than my skirts, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. This boy here *[Indicating the Son.]* was educated away from home; when he came back, he seemed to me to be no more mine. With no mother between him and me, he grew up apart, on his own, with no tie of intellect or affection. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

PLAYER 2 *[the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad]*. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street and smile at me, wave his hand like this. I looked at him, doubtful, wondering who he might be. I told my mother, who guessed at once. *[The Mother agrees with a nod.]* Then she wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again — looking so ridiculous — with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers, all for me.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

THE SON *[turning his face away from the FATHER]*. Literature. Literature.

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She *[Pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER.]*, as you see, is no longer the flapper with plaits down her back —.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the knickers showing below the skirt!

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. Through her stupidity! [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] It's true she can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write to me that they were in need...

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?

THE FATHER. That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments.

THE MOTHER. After so many years apart, and all that had happened...

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them, and naturally my interest dwindled. But the drama culminated, unforeseen and violent, on their return — when I was impelled by my miserable flesh that still lives. Ah, what wretchedness is that of the man who is alone and disdains debasing liaisons. Not old enough to do without women. Not young enough to seek one without shame. It is worse than misery. It is a horror. Every man knows what unconfessable things pass in the secrecy of his own heart. [*A beat. He has to swallow.*] Mine you have already heard. One gives way to temptation, and afterwards tries to bury the shame and walk away from the grave. Some men haven't the courage to say it. That's all.

PLAYER 1 [*under his breath, to Player 3*]. I have several questions. None of them are polite.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Therefore, you want more courage to say these things. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But it isn't true. He is like all the others — though he calls it *courage* when he admits what the others hide. He isn't afraid to reveal, with the light of intelligence, the red shame of human bestiality which most men close their eyes upon. Woman — look at her case. She turns inviting glances on you. You seize her. The moment she feels herself caught, she closes her eyes. It is the way she tells you: *blind yourself, because I am*.

PLAYER 3 [*low, to Player 1*]. Is anyone else following this? At all?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes she can close them no more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only that of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the beast in man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life bestially, throwing aside every chaste aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

THE MANAGER. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she [*Pointing to the MOTHER.*] had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve hers in a different way.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor mamma! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my frocks, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's robes.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

THE FATHER [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time.* Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

THE FATHER. For the drama lies all in this — in the conscience that I have, that each one of us has. We believe this conscience to be a single thing; but it is many-sided. So we have the illusion of being one person for all, of having a personality that is unique in all our acts. But it isn't true. We perceive this when, tragically perhaps, in something we do, we are caught up, suspended on a kind of hook. Then we see that all of us was not in that act, and that it would be an atrocious injustice to judge us by that action alone — as if all our existence were summed up in that one deed. Now do you understand the perfidy of this girl? *She* surprised me in a place where she ought not to have known me — and now seeks to attach to me a reality I could never have supposed I would have to assume, in a shameful and fleeting moment of my life. [*He is sweating through this speech. He has not noticed.*]

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

THE SON [*hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Leave me alone. I don't come into this.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — *you!* I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. I'd like Mr. Manager to witness certain scenes between him and me. He says I have tyrannised. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

PLAYER 1 [*to Player 2*]. This is not in the script. I checked.

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. But imagine, gentlemen, the position of a son who sees arrive one day at his home a young woman of impudent bearing, asking for his father — with whom, who knows what business she has. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there. He has to watch her treat his father in an equivocal and confidential manner. She asks him for money — in a way that lets one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me?

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the MOTHER to the MANAGER.*] See, she's crying!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at the MOTHER*]. Like a fool.

THE FATHER [*indicating Step-Daughter*]. She can't stand him, you know. [*Then referring again to the Son.*] He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. Possibly his situation is the most painful of all. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. [*In confidence.*] The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

THE FATHER. He disappears soon, you know. And the baby too. She is the first to vanish from the scene. The drama consists finally in this: when that mother re-enters my house, her family — born outside of it and superimposed on the original — ends with the death of the little girl, the tragedy of the boy, and the flight of the elder daughter. It cannot go on, because it is foreign to its surroundings. So we three remain — I, the mother, that son — and find ourselves strange to one another. We live in an atmosphere of mortal desolation — the revenge, as he [*Indicating the Son.*] scornfully said, of this damned experimenting of mine. When faith is lacking, it becomes impossible to create certain states of happiness.

THE MANAGER. There is something in what you say. I assure you all this interests me very much. I begin to think there's the stuff for a drama in all this, and not a bad drama either.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*coming forward*]. When you've got a character like me.

THE FATHER [*shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the MANAGER*]. You be quiet!

THE MANAGER [*reflecting, heedless of interruption*]. It's new... hem... yes...

THE FATHER. Absolutely new!

THE MANAGER. You've got a nerve though, I must say, to come here and fling it at me like this...

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

THE FATHER. No. I say born for the stage, because...

THE MANAGER. Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

THE FATHER. No sir, no. We act that rôle for which we have been cast, that rôle which we are given in life. And in my own case, passion itself, as usually happens, becomes a trifle theatrical when it is exalted.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

THE FATHER. Then why not turn author now? Everybody does it. You don't want any special qualities. Your task is made much easier by the fact that we are all here alive before you...

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

THE MANAGER. Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

THE MANAGER *[he is hooked, in spite of himself; the schedule he came in trying to defend is no longer in his mind].* By Jove, it tempts me. I'd like to have a go at it. Let's try it out. Come with me to my office. *[Turning to the ACTORS.]* You are at liberty for a bit, but don't step out of the theatre for long. In a quarter of an hour, twenty minutes, all back here again. *[To the FATHER.]* We'll see what can be done. Who knows if we don't get something really extraordinary out of it?

THE FATHER. There's no doubt about it. They *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* had better come with us too, hadn't they?

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the ACTORS.]* Be punctual, please! *[MANAGER and the Six CHARACTERS cross the stage and go off. The other ACTORS remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man).* Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead).* They are not ordinary strangers.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

PLAYER 1. And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

PLAYER 3. Perhaps there is a play.

PLAYER 2. There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

PLAYER 1 *(as L'Ingénue) [a line about vanity, delivered with no irony whatsoever].* I only know this: if the morning continues like this, I shall require a better part.

PLAYER 1 *(as Door-keeper) [the cap forgotten in his hand; the Leading Man's posture leaking through the doorman's apology].* I only let them in.

PLAYER 2. That is not a defence.

PLAYER 1 *(as Door-keeper).* They looked expected.

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter).* Am I taking this down?

PLAYER 2. Take everything down. It may be evidence.

Thus talking, the **ACTORS** leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.



— *End of Act I* —

The curtain remains up. The action of the play is suspended for twenty minutes.



ACT THE SECOND

II



The stage call-bells ring to warn the company that the play is about to begin again.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER comes out of the **MANAGER'S** office carrying the wrapped bundle and dragging the wooden chair-and-coat behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the chair-and-coat to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

The stage darkens around her. The shower — a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, slow and child-haunted, beneath what follows. She kneels with the wrapped bundle held against her chest, the chair-and-coat leaning a short pace away. She speaks the next monologue live, alone in the column of light.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the bundle and takes the cloth between her hands as if it were a small face].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to a question of the Child.]* What is the stage? It's a place, baby, where people play at being serious — and we've got to act a comedy now, dead serious. You're in it too. A garden — a fountain — look — just suppose, kiddie, it's here, right in the middle. It's all pretence, my pet. All make-believe here. Better to imagine it, because if they fix it up for you, it'll only be painted cardboard — for the rockery, the water, the plants. Ah, but I think a baby like this would sooner have a make-believe fountain than a real one. What a joke it'll be for the others! But for you, alas, not such a joke. You who are real, baby dear, and really play by a real fountain, big and green and beautiful, with bamboos around and a whole lot of little ducks swimming. — *[She turns, sets the bundle down carefully beside her, and reaches for the coat hanging on the chair-and-coat. She takes the coat by the sleeve as if she were taking the Boy by the arm.]* What have you got there? *[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver. She holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket.]* Ah! Where did you get this? Idiot! If I'd been in your place, instead of killing myself I'd have shot one of those two — or both. Father and son.

The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds on her for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the bundle and the chair-and-coat. The Boy and the Child are silent objects again.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

THE MANAGER *[also excited].* If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The FATHER, MANAGER and STEP-DAUGHTER go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, THE SON followed by THE MOTHER, comes out.]*

THE SON *[looking at the three entering office].* Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away. *[The MOTHER attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the bundle into her lap and draws the chair-and-coat close beside her. She casts a glance again at the SON, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

THE MOTHER. Isn't my punishment the worst of all? *[Then seeing from the SON's manner that he will not bother himself about her.]* My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

THE SON *[half to himself, meaning the MOTHER to hear — eyes on the floor].* And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. *[Pauses.]* He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about *my* case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

PLAYER 3 *[very quietly].* Mon Dieu.

The MOTHER hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the ACTORS and STAGE MANAGER return, followed by the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER. At the same moment, THE MANAGER comes out of his office, accompanied by the FATHER and the STEP-DAUGHTER.

THE MANAGER *[trying to take the rehearsal back, his director's voice returning].* Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Heh — you there, machinist!

PLAYER 1 *(as Machinist) [two words; somehow still managing to deliver them as a Leading Man].* Yes, sir.

THE MANAGER. Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

The MACHINIST runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while THE MANAGER talks with the STAGE MANAGER, the PROPERTY MAN, and the PROMPTER on matters of detail.

THE MANAGER *[to PROPERTY MAN].* Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [the Property Man's voice, flat and certain].* There's the green one. It is the sofa we have. It has always been the sofa we have.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* There isn't one like that.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Doesn't matter? It's most important!

THE MANAGER. We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. *[To PROPERTY MAN.]* See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)* *[to MANAGER]*. There's that little gilt one.

THE MANAGER. That'll do fine.

THE FATHER. A mirror.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)*. That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

THE MANAGER *[to the STEP-DAUGHTER]*. We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[she knows the geography of that room — knows where Madame Pace kept everything]*. Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

THE MANAGER. See how many we've got and bring them all.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)* *[a half-nod; she is already on her way]*. Right.

The PROPERTY MAN hurries off to obey his orders. While he is putting the things in their places, the MANAGER talks to the PROMPTER and then with the CHARACTERS and the ACTORS.

THE MANAGER *[to PROMPTER]*. Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. *[Hands him some sheets of paper.]* And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter)* *[looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour]*. Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand*?

THE MANAGER *[pleasantly surprised]*. Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

PLAYER 3 *(as Prompter)*. Yes, a little.

THE MANAGER. Good! *[Turning to a STAGE HAND.]* Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. *[The STAGE HAND goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the PROMPTER.]*

THE MANAGER *[to PROMPTER]*. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. *[Then addressing the ACTORS.]* Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here *[Pointing to the left.]* and listen attentively.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. But, excuse me, we...

THE MANAGER *[guessing her thought]*. Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. What have we to do then — sit and applaud? I can do that. I've been doing that all season — at every other company's premiere in the canton, in fact.

THE MANAGER. Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

THE FATHER *[as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage]*. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

THE MANAGER. A rehearsal for them. *[Points to the ACTORS.]*

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

THE MANAGER. All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" *[Pointing towards PROMPTER'S box.]* — when there is a "book"!

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

THE MANAGER. Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

THE FATHER. As we are...

THE MANAGER. I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

THE MANAGER. You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! *[The ACTORS laugh.]* There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. *[To the SECOND LADY LEAD.]* You play the Mother. *[To the FATHER.]* We must find her a name.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

THE MANAGER. But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... *[Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the SECOND LADY LEAD.]* I see this woman here *[Means the MOTHER.]* as Amalia. But do as you like. *[Gets more and more confused.]* I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

THE MANAGER. Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: *[To JUVENILE LEAD.]* You are the Son. *[To the LEADING LADY.]* You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[a single hard laugh, head turning]*. What? What? I — that woman there?

THE MANAGER *[angry]*. What is there to laugh at?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [indignant]*. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. You should feel honored to be played by...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [at once, contemptuously]*. "That woman there"...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

THE MANAGER. Temperament, soul, be hanged! Do you suppose the spirit of the piece is in you? Nothing of the kind!

THE FATHER. What, haven't we our own temperaments, our own souls?

THE MANAGER. Not at all. Your soul or whatever you like to call it takes shape here. The actors give body and form to it, voice and gesture. And my actors have given voice to material far more lofty than this little drama of yours — which may or may not hold up on the stage. But if it does, the merit of it, believe me, will be due to my actors.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

THE MANAGER *[cutting him short and out of patience]*. Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up...

THE FATHER. Maybe. But the voice, the gestures...

THE MANAGER. Now, look here! On the stage, you as yourself, cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man) [on his dignity — chin lifted, the bearing arranged]*. By me, if you've no objection.

THE FATHER *[with a small bow toward Player 1]*. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man) [the dignity cracking]*. Oh — chuck it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

THE FATHER. The performance he will give, even doing his best with make-up to look like me...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. It will certainly be a bit difficult! *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Exactly! It will be difficult to act me as I really am. The effect will be more — apart from the make-up — how he supposes I am, how he senses me — if he senses me at all — and not how I, inside myself, feel myself to be. So it seems to me that anyone whose job it becomes to criticise us should take this into account...

THE MANAGER. Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the ACTORS and CHARACTERS.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Is it all right as it is now?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

THE MANAGER. My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the FATHER.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

THE FATHER. Yes.

THE MANAGER. Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The STAGE HANDS obey the order. To PROPERTY MAN.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates FATHER.]*

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)*. An ordinary envelope?

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)*. At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

THE MANAGER. Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. *[The LEADING LADY comes forward.]* No, no, you must wait. I meant her *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* You just watch —

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[adding at once]*. How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [offended]*. I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

THE MANAGER *[with his hands to his head]*. Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! *[Looks around as if lost.]* And this Madame Pace, where is she?

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

THE MANAGER. Then what the devil's to be done?

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but where is she?

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! *[Turning to the ACTRESSES.]* If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[half surprised, half laughing, in chorus].*

What? Why? Our hats? What does he say?

THE MANAGER. What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

ALL THREE PLAYERS.

Oh, what d'you think of that? Only the mantle? He must be mad.

TWO PLAYERS.

But why? Mantles as well?

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[taking off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and going to hang them on the racks].*

After all, why not? There you are! This is really funny. We've got to put them on show.

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

THE MANAGER. May we know why?

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? *[Inviting the ACTORS to look towards the exit at back of stage.]* Look! Look!

The door at the back of stage opens and MADAME PACE enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The STEP-DAUGHTER runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her].* There she is! There she is!

THE FATHER *[radiant].* It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

THE MANAGER *[conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant]*. What sort of a trick is this?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[almost at the same time — a hand pressed flat to his chest, as if checking he is still there]*. What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Where does *she* come from? Not from the SSA list, I can tell you that.

PLAYER 1 *(as L'Ingénue)*. They've been holding her in reserve, I suppose. Saving her for the big effect.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. A vulgar trick. And not even a good one.

THE FATHER *[dominating the protests]*. Excuse me, all of you! Why are you so anxious to destroy, in the name of a vulgar, commonplace sense of truth, this reality which comes to birth, attracted and formed by the magic of the stage itself — which has indeed more right to live here than you, since it is much truer than you, if you don't mind my saying so? Which is the actress among you who is to play Madame Pace? Well, here is Madame Pace herself. You'll allow, I fancy, that the actress who acts her will be less true than this woman, who is herself in person.

*But the scene between the **STEP-DAUGHTER** and **MADAME PACE** has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of **THE FATHER**. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by **THE FATHER**, turn round and see **MADAME PACE**, who has placed one hand under the **STEP-DAUGHTER's** chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.*

THE MANAGER. Well? well?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[cupping a hand to his ear, the bearing of a man used to being heard at the back of the house]*. What does she say? Madame — speak up.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. One can't hear a word. Is she speaking at all?

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Louder! Louder please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[leaving **MADAME PACE**, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors]*. Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. *[Indicates **FATHER**.]* But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

THE MANAGER. Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you. What will it be when the public's in the theatre? And anyway, you can very well speak up now among yourselves, since we shan't be present to listen to you as we are now. You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

*The **STEP-DAUGHTER**, level and unhurried, makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.*

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by no?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, no theatrics]*. There's someone who will hear us if she *[Indicating MADAME PACE.]* speaks out loud.

THE MANAGER *[in consternation]*. What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? *[The ACTORS burst out laughing.]*

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. *[Moves away.]*

THE MANAGER *[stopping him]*. No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting him]*. No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

THE MANAGER *[shouting]*. But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... *[Indicates MADAME PACE.]* Do you understand?...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that mamma's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)* *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest]*. Buongiorno, buongiorno, signor — *eccomi, eccomi, j'arrive, désolée pour le retard* — Sì sì, signor, I no wanta be hard. I no wanta take advantage. *[Smiling.]* But la signora she ruin the silk again, *è la terza volta* this month. *La seta non si paga con le lacrime.* Somebody must pay. The mamma she pay with the hands — or *è la piccola* who pay. Either way, signor — *[the smile unchanged]* — the book she balance.

Note. MADAME PACE is supposed to talk in a jargon half Italian, half French — the speech of a Ticinese woman who has lived in Lausanne too long and not long enough. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.

THE MANAGER *[alarmed]*. What? What? She talks like that? *[The ACTORS burst out laughing again.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing]*. Yes yes, that's the way she talks, half French, half Italian! Most comical it is!

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)*. Itta seem not verra polite gentlemen laugha atta me — when I trya speak proper for the *clientela*. My customers — they no laugh. They come back.

THE MANAGER. *Diamine!* Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect will be certain. Exactly what was needed to put a little comic relief into the crudity of the situation. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old signore, eh, Madame?

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)*. Not so old, *cara*. Not so old. He clean. He polite. He pay cash — *la busta azzurra* on the little table, you no even gotta look at his face. He no ask your name. He no need to. And eef you no lika him? Eh — *niente scandalo*. Nobody talk. He bury it deep, like everything else in this town.

THE MOTHER *[jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her]*. You old devil! You murderess!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to calm her MOTHER]*. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

THE FATHER *[going to her also at the same time]*. Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

THE MOTHER. Well then, take that woman away out of my sight!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to MANAGER]*. It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER]*. They can't be here together. And here's why: that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the MOTHER and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

Meanwhile, the **STEP-DAUGHTER**, coming forward again, turns to **MADAME PACE**.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)* *[offended]*. Eh no, *grazie*. The mamma present — *è impossibile*. I have my method, signor. The mamma stay outside, or the transaction it no close. *Anche le galline*. Even the chickens — you no slaughter them where the hen can see.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old signore* who wants to talk so nicely to me. *[Addressing the COMPANY imperiously.]* We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! *[To MADAME PACE.]* You can go!

PLAYER 3 *(as Madame Pace)*. Sì sì, *certo*. I go. I go. Ma *cara* — you remember. Without me, *niente*. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty. *È a me che devi tutto*. La Pace. *[Pauses at the door, calm now, the smile returned.]* And when la signora ruin the next silk — and she will, *cara*, she always do — you know where to find me. Don't you forget the name. *[Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to the FATHER]*. Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over here. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good morning, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

THE MANAGER. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? *[To the FATHER, who looks undecided and perplexed.]* Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

The FATHER does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The ACTORS watch intently.

THE MANAGER *[sotto voce, quickly to the PROMPTER in his box]*. Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

THE FATHER *[coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling]*. Good afternoon, Miss.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust]*. Good afternoon!

THE FATHER *[looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure]*. Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the rehearsed bow — no softness in it]*. No sir.

THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? *[Then seeing her nod agreement.]* More than once? *[Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.]* Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[anticipating him and with veiled disgust]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Takes it off quickly.]*

The MOTHER, who watches the progress of the scene with THE SON beside her, the bundle held tight in her arms and the chair-and-coat pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.

THE MOTHER *[without lifting her head from her hands]*. Oh, my God. My God.

THE FATHER *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry]*. Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 1 *(as L'Ingénue) [interrupting — protective of the company's property, the senior actor surfacing through the wig]*. I say... those are *our* hats, you know.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. *[To the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Begin again, please!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[continuing]*. No thank you, sir.

THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no! I couldn't wear it!

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level, not pleading]*. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her black dress, once.]*

THE FATHER *[a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.]*. ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea]*. Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. *[Tries to smile.]* I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[interrupting and turning to the PROMPTER]*. Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. *[Then to the FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.]* Fine! it's going fine! *[To the FATHER only.]* And now you can go on as we arranged. *[To the ACTORS.]* Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

THE MANAGER. Have a little patience! *[To the ACTORS.]* Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this]*. Of course. It's easy enough. *[To LEADING MAN.]* Shall you and I try it now?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. *[Exit to make his entrance.]*

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING LADY]*. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. One minute. I want to put my hat on again. *[Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]*

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed]*. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

THE MANAGER *[to STEP-DAUGHTER]*. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the LEADING MAN enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the ACTORS from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the STEP-DAUGHTER and the FATHER, not being able to recognize themselves in the LEADING LADY and the LEADING MAN, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Good afternoon, Miss...

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

The STEP-DAUGHTER noticing the way the LEADING MAN enters, bursts out laughing.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating LEADING LADY.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks]*. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the ACTORS to begin again.]* Well?

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Good afternoon, Miss.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. Good afternoon.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[imitating the gesture of the FATHER when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]*. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

THE MANAGER. Good, but not quite so heavily. Like this. *[Acts himself.]* "This isn't the first time that you have come here"... *[To LEADING LADY.]* And you say: "No, sir."

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. No, sir.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. You've been here before, more than once.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The LEADING LADY lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

THE MANAGER *[to LEADING MAN]*. Go on!

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The LEADING MAN says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the STEP-DAUGHTER, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.

THE MANAGER *[low, firm, to the players]*. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[recovering, back into the rehearsed register]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[a step closer, practised gallantry]*. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. Oh come now, don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here, and Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. No, no — I couldn't wear it.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[the smile he has used a thousand times]*. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* *[eyes downcast, on cue]*. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)* *[a beat, then deeply gallant]*. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

*A short, theatrical pause. The **FATHER** turns his face away. The **STEP-DAUGHTER** is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.*

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch].* It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

THE MANAGER *[satisfied, to the **PROMPTER**].* Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, almost to herself].* He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly].* Yes. He said "Oh."

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [breaking character, to **MANAGER**].* Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

THE MANAGER *[tired].* They will sit down.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive].* We will not.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving].* I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man) [two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops].* Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

THE MANAGER *[shouting to **STEP-DAUGHTER**].* Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me! forgive me!

THE MANAGER. You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

THE FATHER *[endeavouring to intervene].* Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

THE MANAGER. Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

THE MANAGER. Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

THE MANAGER. I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

THE FATHER. Just so: actors! Both of them act our parts exceedingly well. But, believe me, it produces quite a different effect on us. They want to be us, but they aren't, all the same.

THE MANAGER. What is it, then?

THE FATHER. Something that is... that is theirs — and no longer ours...

THE MANAGER. But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

THE MANAGER. Well then, let's have no more of it! [*Turning to the ACTORS.*] We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! [*Turning to FATHER and STEP-DAUGHTER.*] Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

THE MANAGER. Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you [*Addressing the FATHER.*] come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*interrupting*]. What?

THE MANAGER. Why she is in mourning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little frock off."

THE MANAGER. Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But it's the truth!

THE MANAGER. What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. What do you want to do then?

THE MANAGER. You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, in the voice men use for children — *well, let's take this little frock off.*

THE MANAGER [*running his hands through his hair*]. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*no longer playing*]. The truth. The truth.

THE MANAGER. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not possible, eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

THE MANAGER. Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part.*

THE MANAGER [*annoyed, shaking his shoulders*]. Ah! Just your part! But, if you will pardon me, there are other parts than yours — his [*Indicating the Father.*] and hers [*Indicating the Mother.*]. On the stage you can't have a character becoming too prominent and overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them all into a neat little framework, and then act what isactable. I am aware that everyone has his own interior life he wants to put forward. But the difficulty lies in this: to set out just so much as is necessary for the stage, taking the other characters into consideration, and at the same time hint at the unrevealed interior life of each. From your point of view, it would be a fine idea if each character could tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. [*softening, sitting on the edge of the table*] You must restrain yourself, my dear — in your own interest, too — because this fury of yours, this exaggerated disgust, may make a bad impression.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*head lowered, not yielding*]. It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

THE MANAGER [*not understanding*]. What? The others? What do you mean?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

THE MANAGER. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? [*She is moved.*] [*The MOTHER at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.*]

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*as soon as the MOTHER becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely*]. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

THE MANAGER. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

THE MOTHER [*changing her low plaint into a sharp cry*]. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

THE MOTHER *[to the bundle, not to the room].* I can't bear it. I can't.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

THE MOTHER *[the bundle in one arm, the other hand on the chair-and-coat — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech].* It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]*

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them].* No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

THE MANAGER *[walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would, if a satisfied audience member could walk].* Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

THE FATHER *[going towards him excitedly].* Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

THE MANAGER *[convinced and pleased].* Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

At the reiterated cry of THE MANAGER, THE MACHINIST lets the curtain down, leaving THE MANAGER and THE FATHER in front of it before the footlights.

THE MANAGER. The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. *[To the FATHER, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.]* Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

★

— *End of Act II* —



ACT THE THIRD

III



When the curtain goes up again, the two-level set of Act Two has been struck. The stage is empty except for a single short fountain basin set centre, its walls high enough that nobody can see inside. The **MOTHER** is sitting on the right, the wrapped bundle in her lap and the chair-and-coat leaned against her knee. The **SON** is on the same side, but away from the others. He seems bored, angry, and full of shame. The **FATHER** and the **STEP-DAUGHTER** are also seated towards the right front. On the other side (left) are the **ACTORS**, much in the positions they occupied before the curtain was lowered. Only the **MANAGER** is standing up in the middle of the stage, with his hand closed over his mouth in the act of meditating.

THE MANAGER *[shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]*. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Our entry into his house *[Indicates FATHER.]* in spite of him... *[Indicates the SON.]*

THE MANAGER *[out of patience]*. Leave it to me, I tell you!

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

THE MOTHER *[from her corner; the head shakes by itself, slowly, twice]*. For all the good that's come of it...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her quickly]*. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

THE MANAGER *[impatiently]*. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

THE MOTHER *[the bundle held high against her chest so that her own face is half-hidden by it]*. I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting indignantly and continuing for the MOTHER]*... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. *[To MANAGER.]* Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

THE MANAGER. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place in the garden, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

THE MANAGER. Why not?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Because he *[Indicates the SON again.]* is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

THE MANAGER. Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. They used to change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

THE MANAGER. Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to guess.

THE FATHER *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]*. The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

THE MANAGER *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

THE FATHER. It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

THE MANAGER. But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

PLAYER 1 *(as Leading Man)*. With our acting.

THE MANAGER. The illusion of a reality.

THE FATHER *[recovering, voice softer]*. I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [interrupting indignantly]*. A *game*? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

THE MANAGER. Precisely —!

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five CHARACTERS.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

THE MANAGER *[astonished, looking at his ACTORS, who are also amazed]*. And what does that mean?

THE FATHER *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile]*. As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the MANAGER and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. *[Looks the MANAGER in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.]* Can you tell me who you are?

THE MANAGER *[perplexed, half smiling]*. What? Who am I? I am myself.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

THE MANAGER. I should say you were mad —! *[The ACTORS laugh.]*

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh. Because we are all making believe here. *[To MANAGER.]* And so you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the LEADING MAN.]*, who is naturally himself, to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see here. *[Quiet.]* You see. I've caught you in a trap. *[The ACTORS laugh — too loudly, too quickly.]*

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

THE FATHER. No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art *[Looking at the LEADING LADY as if anticipating her.]* which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. *[Beat.]* Who are you?

THE MANAGER *[astonished and irritated, turning to his ACTORS]*. If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

THE FATHER *[with dignity, but not offended]*. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

THE FATHER. But only to know if you, as you really are now, see yourself as you once were — with all the illusions that were yours then, with all the things both inside and outside of you as they seemed to you, as they were for you. Well, sir, if you think of all those illusions that mean nothing to you now, of all those things which don't even seem to you to exist any more, while once they were for you — don't you feel that the very earth under your feet is sinking, when you reflect that this you of today is fated to seem a mere illusion to you tomorrow?

PLAYER 2 *[whispering]*. Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[level, never raising her voice — colder than the philosophy]*. His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

A silence. The FATHER does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.

THE MANAGER *[without having understood much, but astonished by the fast talk]*. Well, well. And where does all this take us anyway?

THE FATHER. Oh, nowhere. It's only to show you that if we *[Indicating the CHARACTERS.]* have no other reality beyond the illusion — you too mustn't count too much on your reality as you feel it today. Like yesterday's, it may turn out to be an illusion to you tomorrow.

THE MANAGER *[determining to make fun of him]*. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

THE FATHER *[the greatest seriousness — no smile]*. But of course. Without doubt.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the same temperature; addressing the room, not him]*. He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

THE MANAGER. Ah, really?

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

THE MANAGER. More real than I?

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

THE MANAGER. But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[before the Father can answer — flat, precise]*. His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

THE FATHER *[the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has just shown him]*. No, sir. Not ours. Look here — that is the very difference. Our reality doesn't change. It *cannot* change. It cannot be other than what it is. Because it is already fixed. Forever. *[Quieter, the horror finding him.]* It's terrible. Ours is an *immutable reality*. Which should make you shudder when you approach us — if you are really conscious that your reality is a mere transitory and fleeting illusion, taking this form today and that tomorrow, according to your will. Illusions of reality. Represented in this fatuous comedy of life. That never ends. Nor can ever end.

THE MANAGER. Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy which you yourself have brought me here? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... *[Stops and looks him over from head to foot.]* Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it, because it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. If you want to know, it seems to me you are trying to imitate the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — although I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. In fact, I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. *[Turning to the Actors.]* And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

THE FATHER. I don't know to what author you may be alluding, but believe me, I feel what I think; and I seem to be philosophising only for those who do not think what they feel, because they blind themselves with their own sentiment. I know that for many, this self-blinding seems much more "human"; but the contrary is true. For man never reasons so much, and becomes so introspective, as when he suffers — since he is anxious to get at the cause of his sufferings, to learn who has produced them, and whether it is just that he should have to bear

them. The animals suffer without reasoning. But take a man who suffers and begins to reason about it — oh no, it can't be allowed. Let him suffer like an animal, and then — ah yes, he is "human"!

PLAYER 1 *[low, to Player 3]*. I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

THE MANAGER *[sharp now, no longer amused]*. Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

THE FATHER. I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

THE MANAGER. Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

THE FATHER. Because I suffer, sir! I'm not philosophizing: I'm crying aloud the reason of my sufferings.

THE MANAGER *[slaps the table]*. I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who gets right out of his part and perorates and speechifies as you do. Have you ever heard of a case? I haven't.

THE FATHER. You have never met such a case, sir, because authors, as a rule, hide the labour of their creations. When the characters are really alive before their author, the latter does nothing but follow them in their actions, their words, the situations they suggest to him; he has to will them the way they will themselves — for there's trouble if he doesn't. When a character is born, he acquires at once such an independence, even of his own author, that everyone can imagine him in many other situations the author never dreamed of placing him in.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet]*. Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, I know this.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? Imagine such a misfortune for characters as I have described to you: to be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him; and then answer me if these characters left alive, and yet without life, weren't right to do what they did, and are doing now, after trying everything in their power to persuade him to give them their stage life. We've all tried him in turn, I, she *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* and she. *[Indicating the MOTHER.]*

PLAYER 3. Should we — should someone — stop this?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's true. I too have sought to tempt him, many, many times — when he was sitting at his writing table, feeling a bit melancholy at the twilight hour. He would sit in his armchair too lazy to switch on the light, and all the shadows that crept into his room were full of our presence, coming to tempt him. *[As if she saw herself still there.]* Oh, if you would only go away, go away and leave us alone — mother here with that son of hers, I with that Child, that Boy there always alone, and then I with him *[Hinting at the Father.]* — and then I alone, alone, in those shadows. *[A sudden movement, as if she would seize herself in the vision.]* Ah! my life! my life! Oh, what scenes we proposed to him — and I tempted him more than any of the others!

PLAYER 2 *[to Player 1]*. I had no idea Pirandello was so chatty.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? *[Goes close to the MANAGER to tell him, as if in confidence.]* In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

THE SON *[looking up, for once — directly at the Manager].* Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

THE SON. No, nothing!

THE MANAGER. You too get over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

THE FATHER *[genuinely surprised, almost wounded].* I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

THE MANAGER. Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

THE FATHER. Well — if you take away from me the possibility of representing the torment of my spirit, which never gives me peace, you will be suppressing me. That's all. A man worth the name does not just live; he gives his own life a meaning. *[A beat. Quieter.]* Or — failing that — he invents one, and calls it the same thing. For me, this is everything. I cannot give it up — just to represent a mere fact, as she *[Indicating the STEP-DAUGHTER.]* wants. It's all very well for her. But I am not going to do it. It destroys my *raison d'être*.

THE MANAGER. Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

THE MANAGER. You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

THE MANAGER. If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. *[Indicating FATHER.]* You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

THE MANAGER. Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

THE MANAGER. Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing in the garden... one in the house, and the other in the garden: isn't that it?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless in the garden, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep with her — I, do you understand? — with my vile contaminated body next to hers, with her folding me in her loving little arms. In the garden, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

THE MANAGER. Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. *[Calls a Stage Hand.]* A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. *[To Step-Daughter.]* This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. *[To the Boy.]* Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. *[He stands. He picks up the chair-and-coat himself and walks it across the stage. This is the pivot of his arc: until this gesture he has been the audience, watching from a remove. From this gesture forward he is the audience's complicity made physical. He places the chair-and-coat behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim. The audience must read the move land.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the SON.]* You must send him away first.

THE SON *[jumping up].* Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

THE MANAGER *[at once stopping him].* No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

The MOTHER gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.

THE SON *[to MANAGER who stops him].* I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[calmly — she knows him].* Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

THE SON *[the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives]*. I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. *[To the MANAGER.]* Let me go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[going over to the Manager]*. Allow me? *[Puts down the Manager's arm.]* Well, go on then — go away. *[The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.]* You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, supporting that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose only son he is. *[To the Mother.]* Come on, mother, come along! *[To Manager.]* You see, she was getting up to keep him back. You can imagine how little she wants to show your actors what she really feels — but so eager is she to get near him that... There, you see? She is willing to act her part.

THE SON *[trapped now — and knowing it]*. No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

THE FATHER *[to MANAGER excitedly]*. You can force him, sir.

THE SON. Nobody can force me.

THE FATHER. I can.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... *[Lifts the wrapped bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.]*

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

The SECOND LADY LEAD and the JUVENILE LEAD at this point separate themselves from the group of ACTORS. One watches the MOTHER attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the SON whom he will have to act.

THE SON *[to MANAGER]*. What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]* Ask her how it was!

THE MOTHER. Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

THE SON. Into *my* room. Do you understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

THE SON *[observing the JUVENILE LEAD studying him]*. What do you want?

PLAYER 3 *(as Juvenile Lead)*. Nothing! I was just looking at you.

THE SON *[turning towards the SECOND LADY LEAD]*. Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! *[Indicating the MOTHER.]*

THE MANAGER. Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

THE SON *[the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself]*. Yes — but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? A mirror that doesn't only freeze us with the image of ourselves. It throws our likeness back at us — with a *horrible grimace*.

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

THE MANAGER *[to SECOND LADY LEAD and JUVENILE LEAD]*. He's right! Move away from them!

THE SON. Do as you like. I'm out of this!

THE MANAGER. Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! *[To MOTHER.]* You were saying you had entered...

THE MOTHER. Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. *[A hand at her chest, briefly.]* But the moment he saw me...

THE SON. Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

THE MOTHER. It's true, true. That's how it was.

THE MANAGER. Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

THE MOTHER. I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here. *[Her hand at her chest.]*

THE FATHER *[going to SON in a great rage]*. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

THE SON *[flat]*. I do nothing.

THE FATHER *[taking hold of him and shaking him]*. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

THE SON *[taking hold of the FATHER]*. No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... *[General agitation.]*

The MOTHER, frightened, tries to separate them.

THE MOTHER *[both hands on the bundle, gripping it]*. Please! please!

THE FATHER *[not leaving hold of the SON]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

THE SON *[the voice cracking but the body refusing the cry]*. What does it mean — this madness you've got? *[They separate.]* Have you no decency? That you insist on showing everyone our shame? I won't do it. I won't. And I stand for the will of our author in this. He didn't want to put us on the stage. After all.

THE MANAGER. Man alive! You came here...

THE SON *[indicating FATHER]*. He did! I didn't!

THE MANAGER. Aren't you here now?

THE SON. It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

THE MANAGER. Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

THE SON. Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

THE MANAGER. And then what did you do?

THE SON. Nothing... walking in the garden... *[Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]*

THE MANAGER *[coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve].* Well, well... walking in the garden...

THE SON *[exasperated].* Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! *[The MOTHER trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain.]*

THE MANAGER *[slowly observing the glance and turning towards the SON with increasing apprehension].* The baby?

THE SON. There in the fountain...

THE FATHER *[pointing with tender pity to the MOTHER].* She was following him at the moment...

THE MANAGER *[to the SON anxiously].* And then you...

The stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, beneath the Son's narration. By the end of it, only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain. The chair-and-coat is silhouetted behind the basin.

THE SON *[the only continuous sentence he gives the room; he tells it because he cannot keep it inside any longer].* I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that froze my blood. The boy. Standing stock still. With eyes like a madman's. Watching his little drowned sister. In the fountain. *[The STEP-DAUGHTER bends over the basin and lowers the wrapped bundle into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.]* Then... *[The fountain light holds for ten seconds on the silhouette of the chair-and-coat behind the basin — the Boy watching. Then full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the chair-and-coat is.]*

Lights snap back up at the cry that follows. The Boy is never seen dead — only the silhouette before, and the sound. What remains is the family, the company, the Manager, and the silence the audience has just been made to look into.

THE MOTHER *[runs over toward the sound — and lifts the veil herself, the first and only time she does so in the production, because she has to be able to see].* My son! My son! *[Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.]* Help! Help!

THE MANAGER *[pushing the PLAYERS aside while they lift up the chair-and-coat and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].* Is he really wounded?

TWO PLAYERS. He's dead! dead!

THE OTHER PLAYERS. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

THE FATHER *[with a terrible cry].* Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

THE MANAGER *[He says the line straight — no commentary, no irony, the audience's own thought said aloud by their proxy before they can say it themselves. He turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre.].* Pretence? Reality? To hell with it all. I've lost a whole day over these people. A whole day.

✦
Curtain.

COLOPHON

This is a director's edition rewritten and directed by Kiarash Jamshidi. All directorial readings, scorings, adaptations, and production decisions in this edition — the chair-and-coat and the bundle, the four-stage Father arc, the Step-Daughter's three cuts, the Mother's three silences, the Manager as audience-symbol, the Madame Pace arc from comic to chilling, the Lausanne anchoring, the rehearsal schedule, the Light & Sound score, and every part-note throughout — are his own work.

Underlying play: Luigi Pirandello, Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore (1921), in the public-domain Edward Storer English translation (1922). Source text: Project Gutenberg Australia, eBook No. 0608521h.html (November 2006).

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